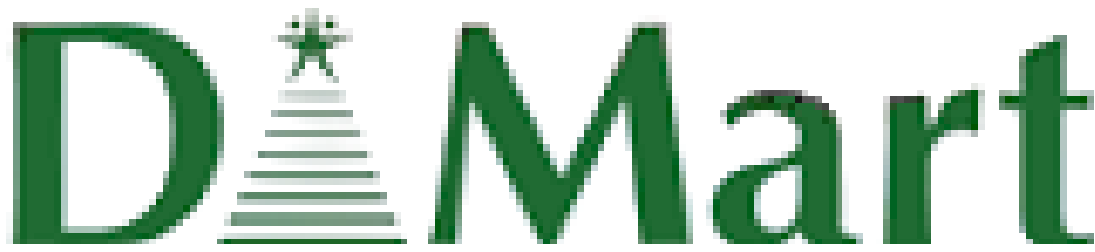




Auto Fill, Flash Fill & Custom Lists

- * What is Auto Fill
- * What is Flash Fill
- * Custom Lists
- * Best Practices



Auto Fill & Flash Fill

Speed up data entry with smart pattern recognition and automation

Auto Fill

Automatically extends a series or pattern by dragging the fill handle (small square at cell corner).

Purpose: Quickly fill sequences like numbers, dates, days, months.

Example: Type Mon, Tue then drag to auto-complete the week.

Flash Fill

Detects patterns from examples you type and fills the rest of the column automatically.

Shortcut: Ctrl + E (Excel) or Data > Flash Fill

Example: Extract first name from "John Smith" by typing "John" then Flash Fill.

Custom Lists

User-defined sequences that Auto Fill recognizes and extends.

Setup: File > Options > Advanced > Edit Custom Lists

Example: Create list: North, South, East, West - then Auto Fill extends it.

Use: Also controls custom sort orders for reports.

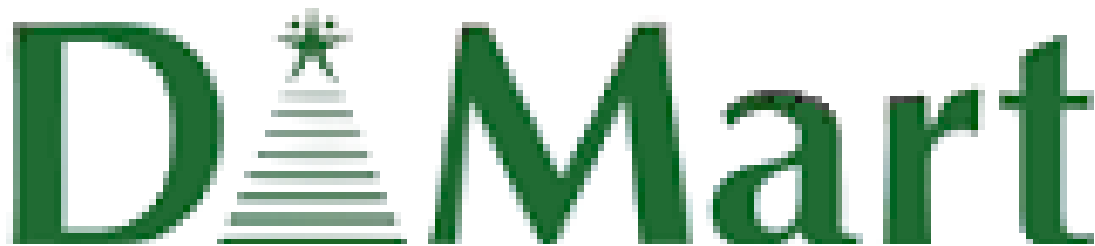
When to Use Each

Auto Fill = Predictable sequences | Flash Fill = Pattern-based extraction | Custom Lists = Repeated categories

Auto Fill: number series, dates, days, months, repeated values

Flash Fill: splitting names, reformatting phone numbers, extracting text

Custom Lists: department names, regions, product categories



Practical Tips & Best Practices

Auto Fill Tips

Hold Ctrl while dragging to toggle between copying and filling a series.
Double-click the fill handle to auto-fill down to match adjacent column length.

Flash Fill Limitations

Works best with consistent patterns - inconsistent data may produce errors.
Always verify results; Flash Fill does not update if source data changes.

Custom Lists Best Practices

Keep lists short and consistent (under 50 items works best).
Custom lists are stored per machine - export/share via documentation.

Comparison Table

Auto Fill: built-in sequences, drag-based, updates automatically
Flash Fill: pattern recognition, example-based, static after fill
Custom Lists: user-defined, reusable across workbooks, supports sorting

Key Takeaways

Auto Fill handles predictable sequences instantly
Flash Fill extracts and transforms text without formulas
Custom Lists standardize repeated categories across workbooks

Pro Tip

Combine all three: create a Custom List for your categories, Auto Fill dates, and Flash Fill to clean imported data - no formulas needed.